



**Special bond:** Bichu insists her relationship with Savita is driven by love, mutual respect, and sisterhood.

"I remember once I was playing at the Sub-Junior Nationals in Ranchi and it was a match against Patiala. Although we lost 0-1, I played really well. I don't even know how. Napoleon [Singh] sir, a coach from Manipur, referred me to the Madhya Pradesh Hockey Academy. That's when I left Manipur for MP in 2015."

After moving to central India, Bichu had to wait for around four to six months to be officially inducted into the academy and receive her own kit. In the meantime, she stuck to physical training or borrowed a senior's kit whenever they were sidelined by injury.

It was only when Bichu was inducted and got her own kit that she believes her journey towards making the Indian team actually began.

"Whatever happens, happens for a reason. If I hadn't played hockey, I wouldn't be here. I also want to thank my father who made me understand,

and perhaps saw something in me," she said.

#### Righting the wrongs

Bichu made 10 appearances in the FIH Pro League 2024-25 season, including two starts, at the end of which India faced the ignominy of being relegated to the FIH Nations Cup. The team conceded the third-highest number of goals (43) in the campaign among nine teams.

"We are mainly focusing on defending penalty corners because that's where we leaked goals. We end up spending about an hour of training on this," she said of how the team is working on its mistakes at the SAI camp in Bengaluru.

The absence of seasoned defenders and midfielders like Udit and Nikki Pradhan also contributed to the team's porous backline, Bichu admitted.

"We had newer, inexperienced defenders. The connection with them was lacking, especially during penalty corners. The positioning went amiss, which would affect my stance as well. It's not completely their fault. In

training, we are trying to improve on how to manage and position ourselves during PCs."

On the other hand, Paramjit believes his ward needs to improve her diving.

"She's a specialist in covering tight angles. All the narrow shots that come her way, she can keep them out. When it comes to diving, she can improve her left side."

"We are disappointed [with the Pro League] but we need to forget and move on. If we win the Asia Cup, we qualify for the World Cup. And medalling at the World Cup will do our confidence a world of good," Bichu said, sounding hopeful.

The keeper won't feel like she's being thrown in at the deep end when playing Asian sides. At last year's Asian Champions Trophy, she featured in all seven matches of India's unbeaten campaign.

From clinching silver at the 2018 Youth Olympics and winning the Asian Games bronze medal to lifting back-to-back Asian Champions Trophy titles, Bichu will now aim to step out of Savita's shadow and add the Asia Cup to her trophy cabinet.